



QUANTUM YIJING INTERNATIONAL ACADEMY

Introduction to the Yijing

Understanding the Basic Structure of Yin-Yang and the Eight Trigrams

"One yin and one yang: this is called the Dao."
— Xici Zhuan (Appended Statements)

Complimentary Learning Resource

A concise introduction to the symbolic structure that underlies the Yijing: yin and yang, the lines (yao), the Eight Trigrams, and the transition to the Sixty-Four Hexagrams.

Chapter 1: The Foundation of the World — Yin and Yang

The Yijing (I Ching) is one of the oldest Chinese classics. It is often described as a foundational work of Chinese thought. Beyond its use in divination, it presents a symbolic system for describing change. At the most basic level, that system begins with two complementary principles: yin and yang.

From the Yijing perspective, the world is not static. Things continually move, develop, decline, and transform. Yin and yang describe two contrasting yet mutually supporting tendencies within this process.

Yin	Yang
	
Softness, darkness, stillness, inwardness, earth, cold, receptivity.	Strength, brightness, movement, outwardness, heaven, warmth, initiative.
Represented by a broken line, called a yin yao.	Represented by an unbroken line, called a yang yao.

The Principle of Dynamic Balance

Yin and yang are not absolute enemies. They are interdependent aspects of a changing whole. When yang reaches an extreme, conditions may turn toward yin; when yin reaches an extreme, conditions may turn toward yang. Day gives way to night, and winter gives way to spring. A central lesson of the Yijing is therefore to observe change and seek an appropriate dynamic balance within it.

Chapter 2: From Taiji to the Eight Trigrams

The Xici describes a highly abstract sequence: "The Changes has Taiji; this gives birth to the Two Modes; the Two Modes give birth to the Four Images; the Four Images give birth to the Eight Trigrams."

The basic building block is the yao, or line. Yin and yang lines are stacked from the bottom upward, forming increasingly differentiated symbolic states.

Taiji	Undifferentiated beginning
Two Modes	Yang line and Yin line
Four Images	Four possible two-line combinations
Eight Trigrams	Eight possible three-line combinations ($2^3 = 8$)

Understanding the Three Lines

Lower line: associated with Earth, the foundation, and the beginning of a situation.

Middle line: associated with Humanity, development, and the central dynamic.

Upper line: associated with Heaven, outcome, and the external environment.

Together these three levels form the traditional triad of Heaven, Humanity, and Earth. Because each position may be either yin or yang, there are eight fundamental three-line states: the Eight Trigrams.

Chapter 3: The Eight Trigrams and Their Basic Attributes

The Eight Trigrams abstract eight recurring natural images — Heaven, Earth, Thunder, Wind, Water, Fire, Mountain, and Lake/Marsh — and associate them with family roles and characteristic tendencies.

Trigram	Form	Nature	Family	Core quality	Memory cue
Qian		Heaven	Father	Strength; vigorous action	Three unbroken lines
Kun		Earth	Mother	Receptivity; yielding	Three broken lines
Zhen		Thunder	Eldest son	Movement; arousal	Yang at the bottom
Xun		Wind	Eldest daughter	Penetration; compliance	Yin at the bottom
Kan		Water / Pit	Middle son	Danger; difficulty	Yang in the middle
Li		Fire / Sun	Middle daughter	Brightness; attachment	Yin in the middle
Gen		Mountain	Youngest son	Stillness; stopping	Yang at the top
Dui		Lake / Marsh	Youngest daughter	Joy; exchange	Yin at the top

Reading the Pattern

Take Kan (Water) as an example: its central yang line is enclosed by two yin lines. In the traditional explanation, this can suggest a strong inner movement within a yielding exterior. Li (Fire) has the opposite pattern: a yin line in the center between two yang lines, traditionally associated with brightness outside and emptiness or dependence within.

Chapter 4: From the Eight Trigrams to the Sixty-Four Hexagrams

Eight basic states are not sufficient to describe the complexity of changing situations. The Eight Trigrams can therefore be paired, one above another, to form Sixty-Four Hexagrams. Each hexagram contains six lines and is composed of a lower trigram and an upper trigram.

Lower trigram (inner trigram): often read as the internal condition, the self, the origin of the matter, or subjective intention.

Upper trigram (outer trigram): often read as the external environment, surrounding conditions, the outcome, or objective pattern.

Example: Hexagram Tai (Peace)

When Qian (Heaven) is below and Kun (Earth) is above, the resulting hexagram is traditionally called Tai (Peace). The traditional image describes the qi of Heaven descending and the qi of Earth rising, allowing yin and yang to interact. It is associated with openness, communication, and flourishing.

Conclusion: Change as the Core of the Yijing

Beginners can easily become absorbed in memorizing the Sixty-Four Hexagrams. Yet the key to understanding the system remains the basic grammar of yin, yang, the yao, and the Eight Trigrams.

The central meaning of yi is change. Human circumstances and natural cycles continually shift through patterns of increase, decrease, opposition, support, and transformation. By learning the qualities symbolized by Qian, Kun, Kan, Li, Gen, Zhen, Xun, and Dui, the student develops a structured vocabulary for observing those changes.

This introductory guide is intended as a foundation. It preserves the conceptual sequence of the Chinese edition while presenting the material in clear English for international learners.

Quantum Yijing International Academy
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